

HAND WRINGING SP chief Akhilesh meets Congress's Rahul and Sonia Gandhi in a more conciliatory time

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CONGRESS-SP TIES

COLLATERAL DAMAGE

By Prashant Srivastava

National friendship on the one side, local turf-sharing on the other. It seems the twain shall not meet for INDIA bloc partners Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Congress. In the Opposition's collective fight against the BJP, if you thought these two 'secular' parties were natural allies, rest assured that's a shaky hypothesis yet to be conclusively proven in Uttar Pradesh. And now they've found a new stage on which to display their sibling petulance: ties have taken a bitter turn after SP chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged that the Congress had reneged on its seat-sharing promise for the Madhya Pradesh assembly poll despite assurances by the top leadership.

SHAKY RAPPORT

- **SP's Akhilesh Yadav alleges that Congress reneged on seat-sharing deal for MP poll**
- **Attacks turn personal as key INDIA allies wage a war of words**
- **Top leadership intervenes, Akhilesh comes around but warns of reciprocal action in UP**

"They made our leaders wait till 1 am but did not give us a seat. I want to tell the Congress, don't talk about our party through your *chirkut* (idiot) leaders," Akhilesh thundered on October 19. The *chirkut* barb was meant for new UP Congress chief Ajay Rai, who had weighed in earlier, saying the SP should "be patient and support" the Congress in MP. "They [SP] should see what the situation is in each state...and anyway, they only had one MLA and he joined the BJP," Rai had reckoned.

The situation escalated, with Rai initiating a ground offensive with the retort that the SP's only intent was to undercut the Congress. For effect, he laced his critique with an allusion to a 2017 incident where Akhilesh had allegedly "disrespected" his late father, Mulayam Yadav. "What else can you expect from a person like him?" Rai asked. With Rai upping his ante by targeting Akhilesh, it was left for SP spokesperson I.P. Singh to do a spot of giant-killing as a return gift, which duty he duly performed by calling Congress mascot Rahul Gandhi a "dimwit".